THE NIGHT WINDOW

Studio Development Package

Confidential

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Logline and synopses

Logline: Before midnight, a repair-kiosk owner must choose between her lease deposit and correcting a battery record that could save a courier cooperative from paying for her mistake.

Short synopsis: Mae’s last customer needs the scanner Mae repaired to confirm a morning delivery route. Under the battery’s label is a refurbished serial; the receipt says new. Inez needs a correction, Mae needs the same money for her kiosk renewal. Neither can afford the accurate version.

Full synopsis: Before midnight, Inez brings a dead scanner to Mae’s kiosk. Testing proves the battery failed; a serial rubbing exposes the part’s actual condition. Mae’s ledger proves her own substitution. Inez considers a false accidental-damage claim, then closes it. Mae proposes tomorrow’s loaner, too late for the morning contract. Outside, Inez’s cooperative roster reveals two other workers depending on her promise. Back inside, Mae offers a refund with a waiver; Inez refuses the waiver. Mae initials its removal, signs a seller correction and refunds the purchase price from her lease envelope. She cancels renewal to prevent an unfunded payment. Inez misses route confirmation and uploads the correction for review, without a promised payout. She buys an eight-unit cable; Mae records its opened condition, then relabels the next refurbished battery honestly. Their transaction ends; their livelihoods remain uncertain.

Complete short treatment

At 11:42, Mae counts one hundred and eighty into a lease-renewal envelope and schedules the midnight payment. Inez arrives at the narrow window with a scanner that will not hold power. Mae asks for a diagnostic fee. Inez produces the receipt for the battery Mae sold as new three weeks ago and the cooperative's route deadline. Mae opens the case and arranges its screws precisely.

A bench supply wakes the scanner; disconnecting kills it. Mae finds an embossed refurbished serial beneath a paper label. She tries to blame the supplier, but her own ledger records refurbished stock sold as new. She makes a pencil rubbing of the serial for Inez. No replacement tonight will fit.

Inez shows a contractual dispute process requiring a seller correction; review promises no payment. She also offers to claim she dropped the scanner under equipment cover. Mae points out the later cost; Inez closes the false claim. Mae proposes a free loan scanner tomorrow. Inez goes outside rather than accept a solution after her deadline.

On the pavement, Inez warns her coworkers not to set alarms. Mae follows with a refund pad. Signing a correction could freeze her supplier account. Inez's coworkers have committed a van and cool boxes; she bought the scanner. Mae brings Inez inside to write on a proper surface.

The refund form says full and final settlement. Inez crosses it out and writes purchase price only. Mae initially offers immediate cash without the correction. Inez insists on preserving the possibility of claiming the lost booking. Mae initials the change and exposes only the relevant ledger row for a photo, protecting other customers' details.

Mae empties her lease envelope, cancels renewal and removes her renewal card. She signs an unqualified correction. Glare spoils Inez's first photo; the second works. The route window closes. Inez submits the correction anyway and counts the refund while the upload turns. Mae reassembles the case, briefly fumbling the screw order under pressure.

At 12:02 the dispute is merely received. Inez tells her coworkers the route is lost. She pays eight for a cable. Mae tests it and identifies it as opened. Inez clears the stool chain at the door. Mae strips another false label and writes refurbished. There is no rescued lease or restored route.

Characters

Mae, 43, woman. Sole proprietor, precise hands, imprecise ethics. Wants lease renewal and access to parts. Her leverage is the original ledger and her signature; her defense is classifying a moral request as a form problem. She concealed a substitution she meant to repair later. S06 forces a waiver decision; S07 turns admission into a cash consequence. Play competence and interrupted habits rather than a confession speech.

Inez, 31, woman. Courier-cooperative coordinator and driver. Wants tomorrow’s route and to remain credible to two coworkers. Her leverage is a receipt and the option to report. She offers her own false claim before refusing Mae’s waiver. She loses the booking, keeps the review alive and pays for a separate item. Her arc is from finding any workable story to insisting on a record she can stand behind. No other speaking characters; Sal and Dev exist only as roster names, with no gender specified.

Tone and formal world

Contemporary, unnamed fictional city. Two spaces share a frontage: cramped kiosk and adjoining pavement. Night creates a visible lit rectangle, not a mystery mythology. Dry humor comes from professional shorthand and friction: a diagnostic fee, a chained stool, an unsuitable drawer. Protect stretches of quiet manual work.

Keep both hands and faces in the same frame when they catch the open scanner (S03), cross out the waiver (S06) and count the money (S07). A restrained change of camera side when Inez enters the kiosk can make shared space meaningful. Sound is small: chain, paper, pencil, screw, terminal tap. No explanatory score is required. Screen inserts must be brief and readable; their wording establishes fictional rules rather than documentary accuracy. No flashbacks, weather spectacle or crowd requirement.

Comparisons and positioning

This package uses craft coordinates instead of claims about named films' revenues, festival histories or availability. A chamber two-hander supplies concentrated negotiation; a workplace procedural supplies pleasure in competent hands; dry situational comedy supplies relief without making lost income cute. Unlike a puzzle short, the secret is exposed early enough for the choice to matter. Unlike a redemption parable, accuracy does not restore the lost contract.

Primary audience proposition: people who have had to negotiate an invoice while someone else waits for pay. The short could sit in a labor, ethics or urban-night program, subject to a programmer's judgment. No commercial performance inference follows from these artistic comparisons. Named comparables would require a later reader's request and deliberate verification; no market research has been conducted.

Casting and performance

Open casting for two women, Mae in her forties and Inez around thirty; ages are flexible if the professional histories remain credible. No named performers proposed or attached. Seek contrasting rhythms rather than accent stereotypes: Mae can be exact while evasive; Inez can be blunt while withholding panic.

Audition S03 for shared physical timing and S06 for disagreement that stays transactional. Mae’s range includes irritation, pride in diagnosis, embarrassment, bargaining and careful admission. Inez’s includes urgency, compromised invention, practical anger and the restraint of counting cash after losing a route. Hands-on rehearsal with a safe prop scanner matters more than a speech reel. Invite performers to challenge jargon that cannot be played. No biographical identity or endorsement is inferred.

Director search

Aspirational profile: a director able to make a sustained two-person negotiation visually active without substituting coverage for decisions. **Practical profile:** a short-film director with demonstrated actor rehearsal and small-location staging. These are search criteria, not named targets or verified availability.

Request a response to the crossing of the window boundary in S05–S06 and a sample plan for legible paperwork without static exposition. A director should preserve both women's agency and resist making the refund a sentimental absolution. A supervised camera-and-prop test should determine whether screen inserts and hands can share focus affordably. No director has been contacted, attached or represented as interested. Next step is a private reader pass, then a prospective collaborator conversation only if separately authorized.

Producer search and assembly

Seek a local short-film producer experienced with controlled night interiors, modest practical builds and fair small-crew scheduling. A cooperative-minded production organization could be a thematic fit, but no company is named, verified or attached. A more established producer could help circulation; that possibility is not an investment thesis.

Producer tasks: independently assess pages; choose practical kiosk versus controlled set; secure permissions; obtain script/prop technical consultation; budget cast, crew, access, insurance, post and contingency. A safe inert battery and dummy screen inserts avoid needing a real failed cell. Verify night access and neighboring signage before promising a two-location saving. No outreach has occurred. The local source package is a development artifact, not a production commitment.

Awards considerations for a short

No award outcome, qualification or eligibility has been researched or promised. A submission campaign is premature before a filmed cut, accurate credits, clear rights and a screened audience response. Demonstrable opportunities on the page are shared physical performance in S03, status negotiation in S06, and restrained sound/prop storytelling in S07–S08.

If completed, first ask whether an awards campaign serves this short's actual audience and available resources. Verify the exact current rules of any chosen body, fees, qualifying routes and deadlines then. Do not divert production funds on the assumption that selection creates qualification or that qualification creates a nomination. This module is proportionate planning, not a prestige forecast.

Festival and alternative launch

An eventual finished short may suit programs concerned with work, urban life, moral compromise or performance. No named festival, selection likelihood or current deadline is asserted. First show a rough cut to a small, consent-based audience and ask whether the refund, missed route and canceled renewal read without explanation.

Then choose a limited, budgeted festival shortlist after verifying runtime limits, premiere conditions, rights, accessibility and fees. Alternative circulation could be a curated community screening with a repair or worker group, by mutual agreement; it must not imply those groups endorse the fictional conduct. An online release can be considered after any actual premiere obligations are understood. No submission or contact has been made.

Budget and scope assumptions

This is an unbudgeted 8–12 minute short, not a financing offer. No numerical budget or recoupment promise. Two speaking performers; kiosk interior and contiguous pavement; no crowds, vehicles in motion, stunts, historical dress or functioning hazardous battery. Night scheduling, location control and readable practical displays are the main cost drivers.

Budget separately for paid prep/rehearsal, production, set dressing, safe duplicate props, sound, editing, grade, music if used, captions, accessibility, insurance, permits and contingency. A controlled kiosk build may reduce street disruption but add art costs; obtain quotes rather than assume. The refund and cable amounts are fictional story currency, not production estimates. Shoot-day count remains open pending blocking and location inspection.

Scene showcase

S03: Two hands on the same fault. When Inez pulls the strap, the open scanner catches. Both catch it, briefly sharing the object they disagree about. Mae makes the serial rubbing rather than delivering an explanatory monologue. This is existing action, not a promised extra set piece.

S06: Repairing a form. Inez crosses out full and final settlement; Mae must initial the change. The conversation turns an abstract apology into a boundary and a preserved claim. The relevant ledger row is photographed with other customers covered.

S07–S08: No rescue. Renewal is canceled; confirmation expires; a dispute is only received. The cable is tested, paid for and accurately described. The ending’s smallest transaction provides the change the script actually earns.

Marketing description

A late customer. A dead scanner. A receipt with the wrong word on it. Before midnight, two working women must decide which version of a transaction they can afford to put in writing.

The Night Window is an original contained short about the price of an accurate record. Inside a tiny repair kiosk, neat screws and neat excuses stop fitting together. Dry humor, practical competence and an uncomfortably ordinary refund lead to a choice that repairs neither woman’s whole life.

Draft-stage description only: no filmed footage, reviews, partners or release date. Intended for adult viewers; no formal rating assigned. The story is fictional and does not identify an actual repair business, courier platform or disputed transaction.

Tagline directions

Transaction: The receipt is correct. The word isn’t.

Time pressure: Before midnight, put it in writing.

Relationship: Two businesses. One bad battery.

Ethical cost: Accuracy has a price.

Each direction describes the existing short. Avoid implying a crime thriller, platform conspiracy or guaranteed victory. A possible poster image is two hands holding opposite ends of an open scanner across a window; no key art exists yet. Typography should preserve the small, ordinary scale rather than advertise a prestige event or quote invented acclaim.

Risks, rights and next steps

All characters, businesses, transactions and display terms are invented. No borrowed text, real people or real events are claimed. This is not a legal clearance opinion. Before production, review title and any actual marks, obtain necessary location/performance/music permissions, and have a repair specialist check safe prop handling without converting invented contract terms into factual claims.

Risks: business mechanics can overburden a short; test comprehension. Night control can exceed assumed scope; obtain location quotes. Quiet acting can look inert; rehearse the catches, cash and paperwork. The writing agent self-reviewed the draft; a second host agent then read the entire screenplay and contact sheets. That reader noted compressed contract mechanics, distinct agency, dry humor and a costly choice. No professional reader or production validation is claimed. The next substantive step is a live read and prop-legibility test, then revise if evidence warrants. All sixteen reader pitches are local drafts; no submissions, financing commitments, attachments, guarantees or outreach. This small demonstration does not establish feature-scale quality.